

CAUTIONS

Just as the Hippocratic Oath states “first do no harm,” the first principle of yoga is *ahimsa*, which translates to nonharm. To avoid harm, it is important to know your body and adapt or modify poses and practices based on your needs and health conditions. Everyone is different, so use these pages as a general guide.

Injuries in yoga do happen, as they do in all types of physical activity, from walking down the stairs to lifting weights at the gym. A meta-analysis of randomized controlled trials, however, found that yoga is as safe as other types of recommended exercise. In fact, yoga may be safer than many forms of exercise because it often incorporates slow transitions, present-moment awareness, and an emphasis on nonharm.

That said, if you believe that yoga practices are powerful enough to profoundly benefit you, you must also acknowledge that yoga has the power to harm, and you must treat it with that level of respect. To prevent injury, therefore, practice the first two limbs of yoga—the Yamas and Niyamas—both in yoga class and in life (see p.205). It is also advisable to bear in mind the following guidelines:

- **We all have** differently shaped bones and bodies, so poses will look different when practiced by different people. Some postures may not be accessible to you without modifications
- **Allow recovery** after strains, sprains, tears, breaks/fractures, surgery, or wounds. After surgery, ask your surgeon for guidance

- **The point of yoga** is not to be able to perform an asana perfectly, or to do any particular technique or pose. Enjoy the journey of self-exploration!
- **Avoid anything that** causes pain or increases existing pain
- **Be careful of** sharp sensations inside the body or sharp, shooting sensations down the limbs
- **Avoid anything that causes numbness** in the limbs.

CONDITIONS

The following pages outline any cautions and considerations for specific health conditions that you should bear in mind when practicing yoga, as general guidance. However, you should always ask your professional medical team what is right for you. If in doubt, work with a qualified yoga professional, such as a yoga therapist.

ACID REFLUX/GERD/HEARTBURN

Be careful of or avoid any full or partial inversion where the head goes below the heart, and fast breathing (kapalabhati).

ANKYLOSING SPONDYLITIS

Be careful of spinal flexion and move slowly into gentle spinal extension.

ANXIETY/TENDENCY TOWARD PANIC ATTACKS

Be careful of inversions, backbends, fast breathing (kapalabhati), or holding the breath (kumbhaka) during symptoms.

ARTHRITIS (including osteoarthritis and rheumatoid arthritis, and other conditions that involve joint inflammation)

For osteoarthritis and rheumatoid arthritis, avoid anything that increases joint pain, and focus on modifying poses for comfort, strengthening, and learning to meditate to cope with pain; for rheumatoid arthritis, avoid hot yoga and overheating.

ASTHMA

Be careful when practicing backbends, holding the breath (kumbhaka), and fast breathing (kapalabhati); avoid intense back bending during symptoms.

BURSITIS AND TENDONITIS

Avoid anything that increases pain or swelling; rest the affected area during acute stages.

CARPAL TUNNEL SYNDROME

Be careful of or avoid arm balances or weight bearing while wrists are extended (e.g. Plank or Crow pose),